



FC GOA HAD THE BETTER TACTICS – AND THE BETTER PLAYERS. MARQUEZ HAD BEEN CLEAR FROM THE START: HE WANTED THE TROPHY AND THE ACL2 SPOT. HE GOT BOTH.

Boss talk: Khalid Jamil and Manolo Marquez, the coaches of Jamshedpur FC and FC Goa.

brought back down to earth by FCG, which dispatched them 3-1 in the semifinal. Goa's foreign contingent scored nine of its 11 goals. Borja and Iker led the way with four each, while Carl McHugh scored one.

Jamshedpur FC, too, under Khalid Jamil, leaned heavily on its foreign core to make the final. All three of its goals came from overseas players, and the centre-back pairing of Stephen Eze and Lazar Cirkovic formed the spine of a resilient defence. But when it mattered most, FC Goa had the better tactics — and the better players. Marquez had been clear from the start: he wanted the trophy and the ACL2 spot. He got both.

In contrast, many clubs from both the ISL and I-League treated the tournament as an afterthought. With injuries mounting and motivation

dipping, it became more about survival than silverware.

What should have been a knockout showpiece became a scheduling chore.

What's next? Even the winners aren't sure

Marquez, despite lifting the trophy, echoed a broader concern.

"I would like a competition with only Indian players," he said. "Obviously, with all the foreigners, the quality is there. But then the improvement of the Indian players is also there." That vision — a platform for Indian talent to thrive — might still be the Super Cup's best shot at relevance. Even for Marquez, who is transitioning to exclusively coaching the men's national team, such tournaments could be his primary

output to identify and nurture talent.

Moreover, Indian club football has always had extended gaps between the seasons, compared to the majority of competitions around the world, which have a two-month break. In this regard, a planned and stretched-out cup competition could just be key to helping teams and players keep up their tempo without risking burnout.

With Satyanarayan ruling out the possibility of expanding the tournament to include teams from lower tiers like I-League 2 and 3, due to the huge gap in finance and calibre of the players, the future of the Super Cup is up in the air.

But for now, it remains a tournament caught between identities: too short to matter, too tired to inspire.